as a soldier. His whereabouts were unknown to the international media for two weeks until he resurfaced in Tawang, in present-day Arunachal Pradesh in north-east India, riding a yak and accompanied by close officials, attendants, guards and his brother, sister and mother. He sought refuge in India. Nehru's government treated him as a guest of honour in the land of the Buddha, a treatment maintained by every government since then.

The Chinese crackdown after the Tibetan uprising of 1959 was severe, and by 1961, close to tens of thousands of Tibetan refugees had poured into India and Bhutan by foot, following their spiritual leader.[53] Refugee camps were set up at Missamari (Assam) and at Buxa in Coochbehar (West Bengal), from where they were dispersed to other settlement sites.[54] As security along the Indo-China border tightened after the 1962 war, escape and return became more difficult. The refugee flow slowed down to a trickle, but it continues even today. Presently, the Tibetan exile population is estimated to be 1,40,000 worldwide, of which around 1,00,000 are based in India in thirty-plus settlements in Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh, Odisha, Madhya Pradesh, West Bengal, Karnataka and Maharashtra.[55] These settlements, like Bylakuppe, are tucked away from the gaze of the public such that most Indians are not aware of them, apart from Dharamsala. The settlements themselves are mostly self-sufficient, carefully preserve the Tibetan Buddhist culture and, barring rare skirmishes, live in harmony with their neighbours. Overall direction is provided by the CTA, first set up in the hill station of Mussoorie in 1959 and later moved to Dharamsala in May 1960. Since its inception, the CTA has been associated with rehabilitation work through education and advocacy for democracy and self-reliance within the Tibetan community.

As refugees, Tibetans don't enjoy the same rights as Indian citizens.[56] India has not been a signatory to the 1951 Geneva Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees and 1967 Protocol (Refugee Convention and Protocol). It did, however, accept the important principle of refugee law called non-refoulement, which forbids returning asylum seekers to a country in which they would face persecution, by adopting the 1966 Bangkok Principles on the Status and Treatment of Refugees. Tibetans and